

The Rebate-Ready Garden

A Rain Garden for Your Downspout

A shallow, planted basin that soaks up roof water, feeds pollinators, and is built to your local rebate program's rules.

25 × 6 FEET · 30 PLANTS · FULL SUN TO PART SHADE · WET AFTER STORMS, DRY BETWEEN



Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

A rain garden is a shallow bowl in the lawn, planted with flowers that don't mind wet feet. You run a downspout into it, and instead of sheeting off the driveway into the storm drain, the roof water sits for a day and sinks into the ground.

Every plant in this plan is native to Maryland. The middle of the bowl gets the plants that like it wettest: swamp milkweed, cardinal flower and blue vervain. The rim and the berm get tougher plants that can take a dry August.

Your local program may pay you back for building one. Page 4 shows what the program pays, what its rules are, and how this plan meets each one. Page 5 is the plant list and checklist, laid out the way the application asks for them.

Don't dig until your application is approved in writing, and call Miss Utility (811) first. After that it's a weekend of digging, a morning of planting, and a garden that waters itself.

WHAT TO BUY

- ☐ 2 Sweet pepperbush
- ☐ 1 New England aster
- ☐ 1 Switchgrass
- ☐ 2 Boneset
- ☐ 2 Swamp milkweed
- ☐ 2 Cardinal flower
- ☐ 2 Blue vervain
- ☐ 2 White turtlehead
- ☐ 4 New York ironweed
- ☐ 3 Golden alexanders
- ☐ 3 Virginia mountain mint
- ☐ 3 Black-eyed Susan
- ☐ 3 Little bluestem

(1)

(2)

(3)

(4)

(5)

(6)

(7)

(8)

(9)

(10)

(11)

(12)

(13)

30 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

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PRINCE GEORGE'S COUNTY EDITION

HARDY IN ZONES 5-8 · PLAN NO. MD-02 · ORBITAL DESK LLC

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The Garden at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Sweet pepperbush

Clethra alnifolia · 3-8 ft · Jul-Aug

Late-summer bees and butterflies. Fragrant; coastal native that handles shade.

2. New England aster

Symphyotrichum novae-angliae · 3-6 ft · Aug-Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

3. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3-6 ft · Jul-Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

4. Boneset

Eupatorium perfoliatum · 2-4 ft · Jul-Sep

Wasps, flies and small bees. Leaves wrap around the stem, as if pierced.

5. Swamp milkweed

Asclepias incarnata · 3-4 ft · Jul-Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Clump-forming milkweed that behaves well in garden beds.

6. Cardinal flower

Lobelia cardinalis · 2-4 ft · Jul-Sep

Hummingbirds. Needs consistently wet soil. Short-lived; let it self-sow.

7. Blue vervain

Verbena hastata · 2-5 ft · Jul-Sep

Bees; seeds feed birds. Tall candelabra spikes for wet meadows.

8. White turtlehead

Chelone glabra · 2-3 ft · Aug-Oct

Baltimore checkerspot caterpillar host. Bumblebees climb right inside the flowers.

9. New York ironweed

Vernonia noveboracensis · 4-7 ft · Aug-Sep

Butterflies. Tall and bold; cut back in June to control height.

10. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1-3 ft · May-Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

11. Virginia mountain mint

Pycnanthemum virginianum · 2-3 ft · Jul-Sep

One of the best plants for pollinator variety. Minty leaves that deer often pass over (not deer-proof).

12. Black-eyed Susan

Rudbeckia hirta · 1-3 ft · Jun-Sep

Many small native bees. Short-lived but reseeds freely.

13. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2-3 ft · Aug-Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Sweet pepperbush → Black chokeberry (*Aronia melanocarpa*)

The Rebate-Ready Garden

What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Sweet pepperbush												
2. New England aster												
3. Switchgrass												
4. Boneset												
5. Swamp milkweed												
6. Cardinal flower												
7. Blue vervain												
8. White turtlehead												
9. New York ironweed												
10. Golden alexanders												
11. Virginia mountain mint												
12. Black-eyed Susan												
13. Little bluestem												

The Almanac: Looking After It

- BEFORE YOU DIG**
Get written approval, call 811, and do the perc test. If water is still standing after 36 hours, pick another spot.
- DIGGING**
Dig the bowl to the depth on page 4, and pile the soil on the downhill side to make the berm. Keep the bottom level so the water spreads out.
- PLANTING**
Plant in spring or early fall. Set wet-lovers in the bottom, rim plants on the sides. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

- MULCH**
Spread shredded hardwood mulch 2-3 in deep between plants, not against stems. No landscape fabric.
- THE FIRST YEAR**
Weed every couple of weeks, and check the inlet after big storms. If soil washes in, set a few flat stones where the water enters.
- KEEP IT WORKING**
Leave the stems up over winter for the birds and bees, then cut them back in late April. The program expects you to keep the garden up, so keep your receipts and photos.
- SAFETY**
Milkweed sap and lobelias are toxic if eaten (NC State Extension). Wear gloves when you cut milkweed, and keep pets and kids from chewing the plants.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

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Your Rebate Packet

Prince George's County · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Program rate \$10/sq ft · at most \$1,500 for 150 sq ft, if approved

Approval isn't guaranteed, and the rebate can never be more than what you actually spend, with itemized receipts; labor you do yourself doesn't count. Cap: \$6,000 per home (lifetime). Minimum size for this project: 100 sq ft. Programs covered: Rain Check Rebate (Prince George's County, run by the Chesapeake Bay Trust). Who can apply: Prince George's County, MD, except the City of Bowie, which runs its own stormwater program. If your town has its own program, check with it first.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	100 sq ft	✓ 150 sq ft
Size vs. roof	20–30% of the roof or paving that drains to it	✓ See the worksheet below
Ponding depth	4–5 inches	✓ Dig the basin 4–5 in below the rim
Drainage	Drains in 24–36 hours (perc test)	✓ Perc test steps below
Placement	10 ft from and downhill of the house; 25 ft from septic or well	✓ Placement notes below
Plants	Native species	✓ 100% native to Maryland (USDA)
Spacing	Perennials 2 ft, small shrubs 4 ft	✓ Perennials 2 ft, shrubs 4 ft
Mulch	At least 2 in double-shredded hardwood	✓ Listed on the shopping sheet

SIZING WORKSHEET

Measure the roof (and any paving) that drains to this downspout: length × width. Your garden should be 20–30% of that area (20% in sandy soil). At 25%, this 150 sq ft garden handles about 600 sq ft of roof. Roof area _____ sq ft × 0.25 = _____ sq ft. If you need more, pick the next plan size up or split the flow between two gardens.

PLACEMENT

At least 10 ft from the house and downhill of it. At least 25 ft from a septic field or well, and 2 ft above bedrock or groundwater. Not over buried utilities; Miss Utility (811) marks them for free.

THE PERC TEST

1. Where the garden will go, dig a hole about 1 ft wide and 2 ft deep. 2. Fill it with water and let it drain. 3. Fill it again, and set a ruler in it. 4. Note the time and the depth. Check every few hours until it's empty. If it drains within 24–36 hours, the spot works. Photograph the ruler at the start and the end: the application asks for the result.

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Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Sweet pepperbush	<i>Clethra alnifolia</i>	3 gal	2	48 in	MD
2	New England aster	<i>Symphotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	1	24 in	MD
3	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	1	24 in	MD
4	Boneset	<i>Eupatorium perfoliatum</i>	Quart	2	24 in	MD
5	Swamp milkweed	<i>Asclepias incarnata</i>	Quart	2	24 in	MD
6	Cardinal flower	<i>Lobelia cardinalis</i>	Quart	2	24 in	MD
7	Blue vervain	<i>Verbena hastata</i>	Quart	2	24 in	MD
8	White turtlehead	<i>Chelone glabra</i>	Quart	2	24 in	MD
9	New York ironweed	<i>Vernonia noveboracensis</i>	Quart	4	24 in	MD
10	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
11	Virginia mountain mint	<i>Pycnanthemum virginianum</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
12	Black-eyed Susan	<i>Rudbeckia hirta</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
13	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD

30 plants · 25 × 6 ft = 150 sq ft · 100% native to Maryland (USDA PLANTS) · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 1.2 cubic yards of shredded hardwood at 2.5 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Apply online through the Chesapeake Bay Trust (Rain Check Rebate).
- ☐ Book the pre-installation site visit with the Rain Check coordinator.
- ☐ Send the pre-approval items: sketch, plant list, site photos, perc test (rain gardens) and the signed Property Owner Agreement.
- ☐ Wait for written approval. Don't buy or dig before it.
- ☐ Call Miss Utility (811) at least 3 business days before digging.
- ☐ Install within 12 months of applying. Keep every itemized receipt.
- ☐ Post-installation inspection, then submit receipts.
- ☐ The county mails a check, about 6–8 weeks after approval.

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The spot before you start, from two angles
- ☐ The perc test hole with a ruler, full and after it drains
- ☐ The downspout and the path water will take
- ☐ The dug basin, before planting
- ☐ The finished garden, with plants labeled

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

The approval letter, every itemized receipt (plants, mulch, compost, rented tools), your photos, and this packet.

SOURCES

cbtrust.org/grants/prince-georges-county-rain-check-rebate (page updated 9/11/26); Rain Check Rebate Application Instructions, 7.2.26; Rain Garden Fact Sheet and Guidelines, 3.2.26; Conservation Landscaping Pre-approval Guidelines, 4.7.26.

DISCLAIMER

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